EXPERIMENT 2

Setting up a Zoho Creator Account and Exploring the Platform Architecture and Interface

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Subject: Low Code Application Development using Zoho Creator
Project: Bank Loan Application & Pre-Screening Management

Aim

To set up a Zoho Creator account, to explore the main areas of the platform (Applications, Microservices, Environments, Users, Organization, Metrics and Billing), and to describe the architecture on which the Bank Loan Application & Pre-Screening Management application will be built.

Introduction

Zoho Creator is a low-code platform on which business applications are assembled from forms, reports, pages and workflows, with the Deluge language available where logic cannot be configured visually. The platform runs in Zoho's cloud, so there is nothing to install: an application is created, tested and used in the browser and, if required, on a mobile device.

Before building anything it is worth knowing where each part of the platform lives. This experiment records the account set-up and walks through the screens that are used in the later experiments on forms, reports, pages, workflows, access control, deployment and security.

Procedure

1. Open the Zoho Creator website in a browser and choose **Sign Up** (or Sign In if a Zoho account already exists). Use the same data-centre site (for example the .in site) in every later experiment, because applications are stored per data centre.
2. Complete the registration with a valid e-mail address and verify it; accept the terms and open the Creator workspace.
3. Note the left navigation, grouped under **Develop**, **Deploy** and **Manage**.
4. Open **Applications** and create a new application named **Loan Application & Pre-Screening Management**.
5. Open **Microservices** and note the tabs available for connections, custom APIs and AI models.
6. Open **Environments** and note the Development, Stage and Production stages.
7. Open **Users**, **Organization**, **Metrics** and **Billing** and note the information each page shows, including the plan in use.
8. Open the new application in Edit mode and identify the Form Builder, Report Builder, Page Builder, Workflow Builder and Deluge editor.

Platform Areas Explored

Table 2.1: Areas of the Zoho Creator workspace

Area	What it is used for	Used in Experiment
Applications	Create, edit, share and manage applications; entry point to the builders	All
Microservices	Connections to other services, custom APIs and AI models that work outside a single application	7, 13, 14
Environments	Development, Stage and Production copies for controlled release	11
Users	Add users and assign roles and permissions	8, 12
Organization	Organisation name, namespace, time zone and administrators	12
Metrics	Usage information; availability depends on the plan	10
Billing	Current plan and usage against its limits	2

Architecture of the Loan Application

The application is organised in the layers shown in Fig 2.1. Users reach it through a browser or the mobile app; the application layer holds the forms, reports, pages and workflows; Deluge scripts supply the business rules; the data layer stores each form as a table; integrations connect to other Zoho services; and the Zoho cloud supplies hosting, authentication and backup.

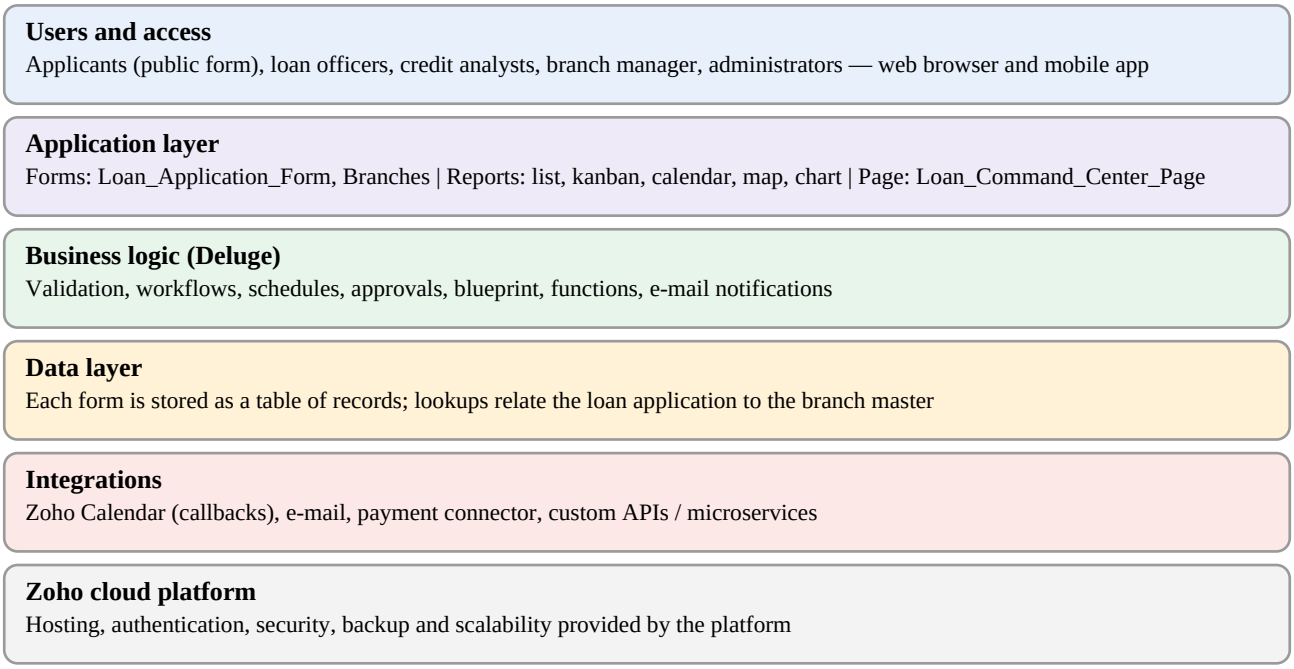


Fig 2.1 — Architecture of the Bank Loan Application on Zoho Creator (schematic; not a screenshot)

Output

SCREENSHOT TO ATTACH

Zoho Creator sign-in or landing page after the account was created

Fig 2.2 — Sign-in / landing page

SCREENSHOT TO ATTACH

Applications page showing the Loan Application & Pre-Screening Management application

Fig 2.3 — Applications page

SCREENSHOT TO ATTACH

Microservices page and Environments page

Fig 2.4 — Microservices and Environments

SCREENSHOT TO ATTACH

Users, Organization and Billing pages (plan details visible)

Fig 2.5 — Users, Organization and Billing pages

SCREENSHOT TO ATTACH

Application opened in Edit mode showing Form, Report, Page and Workflow builders

Fig 2.6 — Application in Edit mode

Result

A Zoho Creator account was set up, the main areas of the workspace were explored, and the architecture of the Bank Loan Application was described layer by layer.

Conclusion

Knowing where forms, reports, pages, workflows, connections, environments and users live makes the later experiments straightforward: the same workspace and the same application are used throughout the lab series.